Mandarin Grammar Refresher

Recovering conversational grammar

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Contents

How to use this refresher 2

Sentence backbone 2

Noun phrases 3

Questions and negation 4

Time and aspect 5

Complements 6

Moving the object 8

Comparisons and modals 8

Connectors and conversational framing 9

Apply it 11

Answer key 11

Quick reference 12

Sources and further review 13

Editorial draft ·Returning conversational speaker ·Simplified characters

How to use this refresher

For you if: you once spoke Mandarin conversationally and still recognize much of the vocabulary, but now struggle to parse sentences or assemble your own. Explanations target a native English speaker's likely habits.

Goal: recover a usable grammar toolkit: find a sentence's backbone, attach its modifiers correctly, express time and results, and connect clauses without translating English word order.

This is modern conversational Mandarin with broadly mainland usage. It skips beginner vocabulary and pronunciation instruction. Traditional characters can be generated from this edition; that changes the script, not the regional variety. Examples have English translations; pinyin appears only where a reading needs clarification.

Fast pass: read Sentence backbone, Time and aspect, and Complements; then do the parsing task. **Full pass:** work through the modules, say the examples aloud, and complete the two short application tasks. Revisit only the constructions that break down in use.

Notation: S = subject; V = verb; O = object. A *complement* follows a verb or adjective and adds a result, direction, degree, or similar information. Square brackets mark chunks for analysis. Patterns are practical defaults, not exhaustive rules.

Diagnostic: five minutes

Try these before reading. Check the Answer key afterward.

1. Parse **我昨天在地铁上看的那篇文章很有意思。** What is the main claim? Which words belong inside the noun phrase? (Noun phrases)
2. Explain the difference between **我没去** and **我不去了**. (Questions and negation; Time and aspect)
3. Explain the difference between **我看了那份报告**, **我看完了那份报告**, and **我看不懂那份报告**. (Time and aspect; Complements)
4. Say "Please send me the address" using 把. (Moving the object)
5. Compare **他们不都去** and **他们都不去**. (Questions and negation)

If unfamiliar vocabulary gets in the way, look it up or substitute familiar nouns. Keep the focus on structure.

Sentence backbone

Put the setting before the action

Default: S + time + place / other circumstances + V + O. Time can also precede S. Chinese verbs do not change form to mark English-style tense or agreement.

- **我明天在家工作。** I'll work at home tomorrow.
- **昨天她跟同事一起吃饭。** Yesterday she ate with her colleagues.

Pitfall: English often adds the setting afterward: "work at home." In the ordinary Chinese setting pattern, use **在家工作**. A location after the verb can instead describe the endpoint or resulting location: **放在桌上**, put it on the table. Position changes the relationship; it is not arbitrary.

For production, build the simple clause first: who, when, where/with whom, then the action.

Topics are what the sentence is about

Pattern: topic + comment. The topic may be an object, a setting, or a larger category; the comment can have its own subject. Context also allows omitted subjects and objects.

- **这家餐厅，我以前来过。** I've been to this restaurant before.
- **这件事，我还没告诉她。** I haven't told her about this yet.

Pitfall: the first noun is not necessarily the person doing the action. In the second example, 这件事 is what is being discussed; 我 is the subject of 告诉. Recover omitted material from context rather than inventing a new English-style subject for every clause.

Identity, description, and existence use different tools

Patterns: A + 是 + noun phrase; S + degree word + adjective; place + 有 + thing; known thing + 在 + place.

- **她是工程师，最近很忙。** She's an engineer and has been busy lately.
- **楼下有一家咖啡店。那家店在银行旁边。** There's a café downstairs. That café is next to the bank.

Pitfall: do not insert 是 just because English uses "is." **她很忙** describes her; **她是工程师** identifies her. Unstressed 很 often makes a neutral adjective predicate sound natural; it need not mean an emphatic "very." Bare adjectives can occur in contrasts and other contexts: **这个贵，那个便宜。** This one is expensive; that one is cheap.

For negation: **不是** is not; **不忙** not busy; **没有** there isn't / don't have; **不在** isn't at the location.

Noun phrases

Put descriptions before the noun with 的

Pattern: modifier + 的 + noun. The modifier can be an owner, a description, or a whole clause. Chinese puts a relative clause before the noun it identifies.

- **我昨天买的手机已经坏了。** The phone I bought yesterday has already broken.
- **坐在窗边的那个人是我同事。** The person sitting by the window is my colleague.

Pitfall: English makes you expect "the person who …"; Chinese makes you wait for 人. In **[坐在窗边的] 那个人**, the whole bracket describes the person. Find the noun after 的 before deciding what the main sentence says.

的 is often omitted in close relationships (**我妈妈**, my mother) and established compact descriptions (**中文书**, Chinese-language book). With a longer identifying clause, keeping 的 is the safe default. If the noun is understood, it can disappear: **红的** means the red one(s).

Quantities need classifiers

Patterns: number + classifier + noun; 这/那 + classifier + noun. Classifiers categorize what is being counted; 个 is common but not universal.

- **我想买两张票。** I'd like to buy two tickets.
- **这本书比那本便宜。** This book is cheaper than that one. (The second 书 is understood.)

Pitfall: use 两 before most classifiers for "two": **两个人**, two people. 二 is used in counting, ordinal numbers, and numbers such as 十二. **第二次** means the second time; **两次** means twice. Useful familiar classifiers include 本 for books, 张 for tickets or flat items, 件 for matters or pieces of clothing, and 次 for occurrences.

Keep 的, 地, and 得 separate

They are usually pronounced neutral **de** in these grammatical uses, but they attach different things.

Form	Job	Example
Description + 的 + noun	Identify or describe a thing	**清楚的解释**: a clear explanation
Manner + 地 + verb	Describe how an action is performed	**耐心地解释**: explain patiently
Verb + 得 + description	Evaluate or describe an action	**解释得很清楚**: explain very clearly

- **她认真地检查了合同。** She carefully checked the contract.
- **她解释得很清楚，我听懂了。** She explained clearly, and I understood.

Pitfall: 得 is not a general substitute for 的. It follows the verb or adjective being expanded, not its object. See Complements for **中文说得很好** and for the separate potential use in **听得懂**. 地 is often omitted in simple spoken manner phrases; its absence is not automatically an error.

Questions and negation

Ask without moving the question word

Patterns: statement + 吗; V-not-V; question word in the position of the missing answer. Use 还是 for alternatives in a question and 或者 for alternatives in a statement.

- **你把钥匙放在哪儿了?** Where did you put the keys? Compare the answer: **我把钥匙放在桌上了。** I put them on the table.
- **你想今天去还是明天去?** Would you like to go today or tomorrow? **今天或者明天都可以。** Either today or tomorrow works.

Pitfall: keep the question word in the answer's slot: **你想吃什么?** What do you want to eat? A subject question naturally starts with 谁: **谁想去?** Who wants to go? Neither needs 吗. For a neutral yes/no question, choose **你去不去?** or **你去吗?**, without combining the formats.

为什么 asks why; **怎么** asks how, and can also express surprise or ask why: **你怎么没来?** How come you didn't come? **呢** can return the question to another topic: **我明天去。你呢?** I'm going tomorrow. What about you?

不 and 没 deny different things

Default: 不 denies a habit, state, intention, or prediction; 没 (有) denies occurrence or realization up to a reference time. 没有 is also the negative of 有.

- **我平时不喝咖啡，但昨天喝了。** I don't usually drink coffee, but I did yesterday.
- **我今天还没喝咖啡。** I haven't had coffee yet today.

Pitfall: these are not simply present versus past negatives. **他昨天不想出门。** He didn't want to go out yesterday. The desire is negated with 不 despite the past time. For an event that did not happen, say **没买**, not 没买了 with completed-event 了. Other sentence-final uses of 了 are a separate issue.

Use **别 + V** for "don't": **别着急。** Don't worry / don't rush. **别忘了带钥匙。** Don't forget to bring the keys. This fixed reminder also shows why "a negative can never appear with 了" would be a bad rule.

Scope: what exactly does the negative cover?

Contrasts: 不都 = not all; 都不 = all not / none. 不一定 = not necessarily; 一定不 = definitely not.

- **他们不都住在北京。** Not all of them live in Beijing. **他们都不住在北京。** None of them live in Beijing.
- **他不一定来。** He may or may not come. **他一定不来。** He definitely won't come.

Pitfall: order determines scope: which claim is being added to, limited, or denied. **我也不去** means "I'm not going either"; **我不再去** means "I won't go anymore."

Question words can lose their question meaning in a construction such as **谁都知道。** Everyone knows. **我什么都没买。** I didn't buy anything. With negation and 都, do not translate 什么 mechanically as a question.

Time and aspect

Time expressions say **when**. Aspect presents an event as realized, experienced, ongoing, or a maintained state. Chinese does not require every clause to carry an aspect particle. Context often supplies the time.

Verb 了: present an event as realized

Pattern: V + 了 + O, often with a quantity or other specification of the object. Perfective 了 views the event as a bounded occurrence; it does not by itself mean the entire task reached its intended endpoint.

- **我昨天看了三页。** I read three pages yesterday.
- **明天吃了早饭再出门。** Tomorrow, go out after having breakfast.

Pitfall: 了 is not an English past-tense ending. The second example places the event in the future. And **我看了那本书，但是没看完。** I read that book, but didn't finish it. To state completion of the whole reading task, use 完.

For a denial: **我没看那本书。** I didn't read that book. For a question: **你看了没有?** Did you read it? Past time alone does not require 了: **我小时候住在上海。** I lived in Shanghai as a child.

Sentence-final 了: update the situation

Pattern: clause + 了. It signals a changed situation or a newly relevant state. At the end of a short sentence, the event and situation-update readings can overlap; not every 了 can be classified by position alone.

- **现在不下雨了。** It's not raining anymore.
- **我不去了。** I'm not going after all / anymore.

Pitfall: compare **我没去** (I didn't go) with **我不去了** (I've changed my plan / won't go now). The latter is an update about the situation, not a completed negative action.

我饿了。 I'm hungry now. No completed action needs to be imagined. **快下雨了。** It's going to rain soon. Again, nothing has happened yet.

For possession or availability, negate 有 with 没有: **我没有现金了。** I'm out of cash. "No longer" is not always 不…了.

过: experience, rather than an event report

Pattern: V + 过 + O; negative 没 (有) + V + 过 + O. 过 presents an experience before the relevant reference time, often at least once.

- **我去过成都，但没去过重庆。** I've been to Chengdu, but not Chongqing.
- **这道菜我以前吃过。** I've had this dish before.

Pitfall: 昨天我去了成都 reports a particular trip yesterday; **我去过成都** foregrounds having that experience. English "have" does not automatically call for 过: "I've lost my keys" would ordinarily be **我的钥匙丢了**, an event/current problem, rather than a claim about prior experience.

在 and 着: ongoing actions and states

Patterns: 在/正在 + V foregrounds an action in progress; V + 着 often presents a continuing state or background action. 着 is **zhe** here, not the **zháo** in 睡着 (fall asleep).

- **她正在开门。门开着呢。** She's opening the door. The door is open.
- **他戴着耳机工作。** He's working with headphones on.

Pitfall: 开着 describes the open state in this context, not the motion of opening. Do not add 在 to every English "-ing": adjective states and activities that Chinese presents differently need their own constructions. **我知道** means "I know"; it is not normally 正在知道.

我在看书呢。 I'm reading. 呢 can reinforce an ongoing scene; it does not mark progression in every use. 着 can also accompany an ongoing activity, so the distinction is about focus, not simply "action versus no action."

Duration, frequency, and "still continuing"

Defaults: put time-when before the action and duration after the verb. With an object, repeating the verb is one clear way to attach duration. 次 counts occurrences; 遍 counts complete passes through material.

- **我昨天看书看了两个小时。** I read for two hours yesterday.
- **我已经学了三年中文了。** I've been studying Chinese for three years now.

Pitfall: distinguish **三年前** (three years ago), **三年** (for three years), and **三次** (three times). The second example normally suggests study continuing to now. Final 了 relates the accumulated duration to the present; context determines whether study continues. Compare **我以前学过三年中文。** I previously studied Chinese for three years.

看了两次 means read/looked at it twice; **看了两遍** specifies two passes from beginning to end. Neither guarantees understanding. **十分钟以后再来** means come back in ten minutes, not stay for ten minutes.

Complements

Read the verb and its complement together before translating. 听懂, 听得懂, and 听不懂 make different claims.

Result: what did the action achieve?

Pattern: V + result, optionally followed by 了 and an object. Common results: 完 finished, 懂 understood, 到 reached/obtained, 见 perceived, 好 ready/satisfactorily done, 错 wrong.

- **我听见了，但没听懂。** I heard it, but didn't understand.
- **我把地址写错了。** I wrote the address incorrectly.

Pitfall: 听 means listen; **听见** means hear; **听懂** means understand what one hears. An action and a successful result are different claims. **找了很久，还是没找到。** I looked for a long time and still didn't find it.

完 gives an endpoint, whereas 好 often suggests readiness or satisfactory completion: **饭做好了。** The meal is ready. A result complement does not itself locate the event in the past: **看完再告诉我。** Tell me after you finish reading.

Potential: can the result be achieved?

Pattern: V + 得 / 不 + result or directional complement. This often describes practical possibility under the circumstances. The negative is inside the package.

- **你说慢一点儿，我就听得懂。** If you speak a little more slowly, I can understand.
- **这个箱子太大，放不进去。** This box is too big; it won't fit inside.

Pitfall: 没听懂 reports that understanding did not happen; **听不懂** says you cannot make sense of it under the current conditions. **听不见** means you cannot hear it. **不能听** concerns the possibility or permission to listen, without specifically identifying failure to understand.

Compare **这份报告我今天写不完。**I can't finish this report today. **这份报告我今天不写，明天再写。**I'm not writing this report today; I'll write it tomorrow. Inability to achieve a result differs from deciding not to act.

Degree and manner: how well, how far, with what effect?

Pattern: V + 得 + description; adjective + 得 + consequence. If the verb has an object, move the object earlier or repeat the verb.

- **她中文说得很流利。** She speaks Chinese fluently. Also: **她说中文说得很流利。**
- **我累得不想说话。** I'm so tired I don't want to talk.

Pitfall: don't leave the object between the verb and 得: for "speaks Chinese well," use **中文说得很好** or **说中文说得很好**. To deny the quality, say **说得不好**, not 不说得好. **不说** would deny speaking.

The 得 in **听得懂** marks potential, while **说得很清楚** evaluates clarity. Some short forms, such as **做得好**, can depend on context. Longer descriptive phrases and the corresponding negative often reveal the construction: **做得不好** evaluates quality; **做不好** can express inability to achieve a good result.

Direction: movement relative to a viewpoint

Pattern: V + direction + 来/去. 来 moves toward the contextual viewpoint; 去 moves away. Frequent combinations include 进来/进去, 出来/出去, 回来/回去, 上来/上去, 下来/下去.

- **外面太冷了，快进来。** It's too cold outside; come in.
- **请把这把椅子搬出去。** Please move this chair out.

Pitfall: choose 来/去 by viewpoint, not by the English word "in." With a place object, put the place before the final 来/去: **走进教室来**, walk into the classroom toward the viewpoint. With an object being moved, 把 often keeps the structure clear, as in the chair example.

Direction also extends beyond physical movement: **想起来了** means remembered; **继续说下去** means keep speaking. Learn these as meaning-bearing chunks rather than translating each character literally.

Moving the object

把: foreground what happens to a particular thing

Pattern: S + (negation / modal) + 把 + identifiable O + V + result / destination / other elaboration. Use it to track an affected object and what is done to it.

- **请把地址发给我。** Please send me the address.
- **我没把那份报告看完。** I didn't finish reading that report.

Pitfall: 把 is not a generic object marker for every transitive sentence. A safe production strategy is a known/specified object and a concrete outcome. **把门关上** (close the door) and **把书放在桌上** (put the book on the table) are useful packages. Verbs such as 喜欢 do not ordinarily describe this kind of handling: **我喜欢这本书。** I like this book.

Place the clause-level negation or modal before 把: **别把手机忘在车里。** Don't leave your phone in the car. A bare verb after the object often feels incomplete; add a result, destination, or other elaboration. **把这段话读一下。** Take a moment to read this passage. 一下 elaborates the action without naming a result.

被: foreground the affected participant

Pattern: affected S + 被 + (agent) + V + result / elaboration. The agent may be omitted. Common in adverse events, but not limited to them.

- **我的自行车被人偷走了。** My bicycle was stolen.
- **这个问题已经被解决了。** This problem has already been solved.

Pitfall: do not turn every English passive into 被. Chinese can often leave an agent unexpressed without a passive marker: **票买好了。** The tickets have been bought / are all sorted. Use 被 when the affected participant and what happened to it deserve attention.

For a negative: **门没被锁上。** The door wasn't locked. Recognize conversational passives with 让 or 叫 too, but remember that those words also mean let/make and call. Context must decide.

Comparisons and modals

Compare along a stated dimension

Patterns: A + 比 + B + adjective; A + 没有 + B + adjective; A + 跟 + B + 一样 + adjective. Put an exact difference after the adjective.

- **这条路比那条短两公里。** This route is two kilometers shorter than that one.
- **今天没有昨天那么冷。** Today isn't as cold as yesterday. **这间房跟那间一样大。** This room is as big as that one.

Pitfall: use **比以前好得多** (much better than before), not 比以前很好 for the ordinary comparative. **不比** denies being more; **没有** states falling short: **他不比我高** says he isn't taller than me, allowing equal height; **他没有我高** says he isn't as tall as me.

越来越 + adjective expresses change over time: **天气越来越热。** The weather is getting hotter. **越 A 越 B** links variation in A to variation in B: **越说越流利。** The more you speak, the more fluent you become.

会, 能, 可以, 想, 要: choose the relationship

Default meanings: 会 learned ability or prediction; 能 ability/possibility under circumstances; 可以 permission or acceptable possibility; 想 desire/intention; 要 want, intend, require, or an imminent development, depending on context.

- **我会开车，但今天太累，不能开。** I can drive, but I'm too tired to drive today.
- **这里可以停车吗？我想停十分钟。** Is parking allowed here? I'd like to park for ten minutes.

Pitfall: these overlap, but they are not interchangeable translations of "can" and "will." **他会来的。** He'll come (a confident prediction). **他要来了。** He's about to come. **我不会游泳。** I don't know how to swim. **我不能游泳。** I can't swim in the present circumstances / am not allowed to.

For "don't need to," use **不用** or **不必**: **你不用等我。** You don't need to wait for me. **不要等我** is an instruction not to wait, not a statement that waiting is unnecessary. **应该** means should: **你应该早点休息。** You should get some rest earlier.

Connectors and conversational framing

就 and 才: timing, thresholds, and expectations

Patterns: time / condition + 就 + action; time / condition + 才 + action. 就 often suggests promptness, sufficiency, or "then"; 才 often marks a late threshold or "only then." Their other uses depend on construction.

- **他七点就到了，我九点才到。** He arrived as early as seven; I didn't arrive until nine.
- **十分钟就够了。** Ten minutes is enough. **我才等了十分钟。** I've only waited ten minutes.

Pitfall: 才 can mark a late threshold or a surprisingly small quantity. Compare "not until nine" with "only ten minutes." Read the time or quantity it comments on; neither 才 nor 就 has one fixed English translation.

一到家就给我打电话。 Call me as soon as you get home. Here 一...就...links an immediate sequence; it is not a count of one phone call.

又, 再, 还, 已经: orient the event

Defaults: 又 repeats an occurrence; 再 proposes or projects repetition / a later next step; 还 means still or additionally; 已经 means already.

- **他昨天又迟到了。明天别再迟到了。** He was late again yesterday. Don't be late again tomorrow.
- **我已经吃过了，但她还没吃。** I've already eaten, but she hasn't eaten yet.

Pitfall: 又 and 再 are not fixed past and future tense markers. **明天又是星期一。** Tomorrow it's Monday again. It presents a recurring situation even though it is future. Use construction and perspective, rather than an English tense rule.

先吃饭，再讨论。 Eat first, then discuss it. 再 here orders a next step. **还要一杯水。** I'd also like a glass of water. 还 adds an item; that need not mean a second glass of water. It is hái here; huán means return/give back in a different lexical use.

Connect the logic of clauses

Useful pairs: 因为…所以…because/therefore; 虽然…但是…although/but; 如果/要是…就…if/then; 只要…就… provided/then; 只有…才…only if/only then.

- **虽然很忙，但是我还是想去。** Although I'm busy, I still want to go.
- **只要有时间，我就去。只有周末，我才有时间。** As long as I have time, I'll go. I only have time on weekends.

Pitfall: Chinese commonly uses both halves of 因为…所以...and 虽然…但是..., unlike their usual English translations. One half can be omitted when the relation is clear. **只要** makes its condition sufficient: having time is enough for me to go. **只有** makes its condition necessary: being a weekend is required for me to have time.

For ordinary sentences, connect nouns with 和/跟, and clauses with an appropriate connector or a pause: **我买了菜，然后回家做饭。** I bought groceries, then went home to cook. Do not use 和 as the default English "and" between full clauses. **一边做饭一边听播客。** Cook while listening to a podcast: two simultaneous activities.

是...的: focus on a detail

Pattern: S + 是 + focused time / place / manner / agent detail + V + 的. A major use highlights details of an event treated as established in the conversation. 是 is often omitted in affirmative speech.

- **我是去年搬来的。** It was last year that I moved here.
- **这张照片是我朋友拍的。** This photo was taken by my friend. (Focus on who took it.)

Pitfall: 我去年搬来了 reports the move; **我是去年搬来的** highlights when. To deny the focused detail, retain 是: **我不是去年搬来的，是前年。** I moved here the year before last, not last year. A different emphatic 是…的 pattern can concern the future: **他是会来的。** He really will come. Do not treat 是…的 as a past-tense ending.

Small forms that make speech usable

Patterns: V + 一下 or verb reduplication for a brief/limited action; 吧 for suggestions or softened directives; 呢 for a continuing topic or scene. These affect conversational stance as well as literal content.

- **你看一下这个地址，对不对?** Take a quick look at this address. Is it right?
- **我们先坐下聊聊吧。** Let's sit down and chat for a bit first.

Pitfall: particles do not automatically make every demand polite. Relationship, intonation, and wording still matter. **给我看看。** Let me have a look. This can be ordinary among friends, but a more considerate request to a stranger is **可以让我看一下吗?** Could you let me take a quick look?

Contextual pronunciation worth recognizing

These readings help connect a familiar character to its grammatical role:

- **不** is normally bù; before a fourth tone it becomes bú: **不是** bú shì. **一** changes in many connected contexts: **一天** yì tiān; **一个** yí ge (个 is commonly neutral, with an underlying fourth tone). Counting and ordinals often retain yī. In **去不去** qù bu qù and **看一看** kàn yi kàn, the middle syllable is commonly neutral. Dictionaries may show underlying tones.

- **了** is neutral le as a particle, but liǎo in **受不了** shòu bu liǎo (can't stand it). **得** is neutral de in complements, děi in **我得走了** (I have to go), and dé in **得到** (obtain).

Pitfall: identical characters can have different readings within one sentence. In Task 2, **去不了了** is qù bu liǎo le: "cannot go" plus a situation update.

Apply it

Task 1: parse before translating

Spend five to ten minutes on this paragraph. Bracket the long noun phrase, identify the main predicates, and label the result, potential, and 把 constructions. Then give an idiomatic English translation.

我昨天在地铁上看的那篇文章，你看完了吗？我看了两遍，还是有几句看不懂。你要是有时间，就把最难的那一段给我解释一下吧。

Check that you can explain what the speaker read, what remains difficult, and what help they request.

Task 2: recover a useful message

Write or say a six-to-eight-sentence message to a friend. You planned to meet tonight, worked longer than expected, have not finished a report, and propose meeting tomorrow instead. Include:

- A contrast between the original plan and the updated situation.
- An unachieved result, not just a negated action.
- A conditional proposal.
- A request to send you the address, and a statement about what to do on arrival.

Spend ten minutes, then compare with the model. Different wording is welcome. A listener should be able to reconstruct your plan, the obstacle, and the requested next steps.

Answer key

Diagnostic

1. **[我昨天在地铁上看的] 那篇文章 / 很有意思。** Main claim: that article is interesting. The bracket means "that I read on the subway yesterday"; it modifies 文章. 我 is the subject inside the modifier, not the subject of 很有意思. Translate: "The article I read on the subway yesterday is interesting."
2. **我没去**: I didn't go / haven't gone. It denies the occurrence. **我不去了**: I'm not going after all / anymore. It updates the plan or situation.
3. **我看了那份报告**: I read that report; it does not by itself guarantee I finished it. **我看完了那份报告**: I finished reading it. **我看不懂那份报告**: I can't understand the report. The final two use result and potential complements, respectively.
4. **请把地址发给我。** 请 softens the request; 把 introduces the identifiable address; 发给我 states the transfer to me.
5. **他们不都去**: not all of them are going. **他们都不去**: none of them are going. In this context, 不 before 都 denies the universal claim; 都 before 不 distributes the negative across everyone.

Task 1 model

[我昨天在地铁上看的] 那篇文章，你看完了吗？ The bracket modifies 文章, and the entire article phrase is the topic. Main clause: 你看完了吗？ **看完** is read + finish.

我看了两遍，还是有几句看不懂。 The speaker read it twice; 遍 counts complete passes through material. **看不懂** is inability to understand; **有几句** introduces the few sentences that remain problematic. Reading through something and understanding it are separate outcomes.

你要是有时间，就把最难的那一段给我解释一下吧。 要是...就...gives a condition and requested response. 把 marks the particular paragraph to be explained. **给我** identifies the person receiving the explanation. 一下 limits the request, and 吧 softens it.

"Have you finished reading the article I read on the subway yesterday? I've read it twice, but there are still a few sentences I can't understand. If you have time, could you explain the hardest paragraph to me?"

Task 2 model

我们本来约好今晚见面。可是我今天加班，九点才下班。报告还没写完。我今晚去不了了。要是你明天有时间，我们就明天见吧。请把地址发给我。我到了以后就给你打电话。

"We originally agreed to meet tonight. But I worked overtime today and didn't get off work until nine. The report still isn't finished. I can't make it tonight after all. If you have time tomorrow, let's meet tomorrow. Please send me the address. I'll call you once I arrive."

Notice **才** marking a late time, **没写完** denying an achieved result, **去不了** describing inability to go, and final **了** updating the situation. **到了以后** establishes arrival as the condition for the later call; it does not make the call a past event.

Quick reference

A parsing routine

1. Find the main predicate. Does it say identity (是), description (adjective), existence (有), location (在), or an action?
2. Bracket each long **...的 + noun** group. Find where the modifier ends before interpreting the main clause.
3. Recover the topic, subject, and omitted objects from context.
4. Read the full verb package: action + result/direction; potential 得/不; descriptive 得; aspect particles.
5. Check negation and adverb scope. Then connect clauses by time, condition, contrast, or cause.

Choose the construction by the message

What you want to say	Useful pattern
Present an event as realized	V + 了; not required for every past event
A situation has changed	Clause + 了
Something did not happen	没 (有) + V
No longer / no longer have	不 + predicate + 了 / 没有 + noun + 了
You have prior experience	V + 过
An action is in progress	在/正在 + V
State / background activity	V + 着
An action achieved a result	V + result

What you want to say	Useful pattern
A result cannot be achieved	V + 不 + result
You describe performance	V + 得 + description
A known object is handled	把 + O + V + elaboration
A participant is affected	Affected S + 被 + (agent) + V…
You identify a thing	Modifier + 的 + noun
You highlight an event detail	是 + detail + V + 的

Recover by producing contrasts

After reading, make one personal sentence for each pair: 不/没; 了/过; 在/着; 没听懂/听不懂; 不都/都不; 就/才; 只要/只有. If the meaning changes as intended, move on. If not, return to that unit and say the examples in a new context.

Sources and further review

This original teaching draft received an editorial pass for accuracy, example naturalness, translation, and density on 2026-11-10. It has not received independent human language review. These teaching references support further study and the distinctions checked during revision.

- University of Oxford, Centre for Teaching Chinese as a Foreign Language, grammar database index. Further explanations of aspect, complements, word order, and related constructions.
- Oxford CTCFL, the 得 construction and potential complements: object placement, descriptive versus potential 得, and negation; the 把 construction: affected objects and elaborated verb phrases; comparatives: 比, 没有, and 一样.
- Palacký University Olomouc, ChinGram, teacher's guide to 着/著: persistent states, accompanying actions, and the contrast with 在.
- Education University of Hong Kong, tone sandhi of 一: contextual tone changes, with recorded examples.
- Cheng & Tsui, *Integrated Chinese*, third edition, Level 1 Part 1, publisher's lesson sample, grammar discussion of 了: why it is not a past-tense marker, including future event sequences.
- OpenCC project: the tool used for the optional traditional-character edition. Automated script conversion does not establish regional usage or linguistic review.

The initial references were checked on 2026-11-09; the editorial pass added targeted checks on 2026-11-10. Human language review remains the next step before marking the course independently reviewed.